Mednogorsk was then in the Mediterranean off the shore of Algeria. The ship was carrying 2,400 tons of military equipment, with 274 officers and soldiers on board. Ignoring the protests of crew members who were eager to complete the journey, the captain did as ordered—the *Mednogorsk* turned back and, after clearing the Dardanelles, entered the Black Sea and headed for its home port of Mykolaiv.[11]

The ships closer to the Cuban shores were ordered to proceed to the island—five ships altogether. One, the cargo ship *Divnogorsk*, was spotted by American airplanes on the approaches to Cuba on the night of October 22. As reported later by a KGB officer on board the ship, a US airplane with its searchlights on overflew the *Divnogorsk* not once or twice but seven times. But apart from those acts of surveillance, bordering on harassment, the ship was left alone: no signals or orders were issued to stop it. The *Divnogorsk* reached the port of Mariel safely at 2:00 a.m. on October 23. Only then was the captain informed that the United States had introduced a blockade of the island, and "American naval vessels and airplanes were scouring the Caribbean Sea, the straits and Cuban ports in order to seize our transports." They all heaved a sigh of relief.[12]

Among the vessels specifically ordered to remain on course was the dry cargo ship *Aleksandrovsk*. It was bringing the most dangerous cargo of all, twenty-four nuclear warheads for the IRBM R-14 missiles still en route, and forty-four warheads for the cruise missiles already on the island. Khrushchev and his advisers decided that the *Aleksandrovsk* should head for the nearest Cuban port as quickly as possible. It was supposed to dock at Mariel, but the Soviets intercepted American communications indicating that they were looking for a ship adapted for carrying nuclear warheads, and two American planes overflew the port of Mariel on the afternoon of October 23. The *Aleksandrovsk*, running behind schedule, was ordered to change course and head for the port of La Isabela. Moscow waited eagerly to hear whether it had managed to beat the blockade. The letter from President Kennedy received in Moscow early in the morning of October 24 gave the exact time when the blockade was to be implemented: "14:00 hours Greenwich time October twenty-four."[13]

◊◊◊